

Opinion of the Court

“in a broad variety of areas, many of them highly sensitive,” frequently makes it “difficult to determine which of [his] innumerable ‘functions’ encompassed a particular action.” *Id.*, at 756. And some Presidential conduct—for example, speaking to and on behalf of the American people, see *Trump v. Hawaii*, 585 U. S. 667, 701 (2018)—certainly can qualify as official even when not obviously connected to a particular constitutional or statutory provision. For those reasons, the immunity we have recognized extends to the “outer perimeter” of the President’s official responsibilities, covering actions so long as they are “not manifestly or palpably beyond [his] authority.” *Blassingame v. Trump*, 87 F. 4th 1, 13 (CADC 2023) (internal quotation marks omitted); see *Fitzgerald*, 457 U. S., at 755–756 (noting that we have “refused to draw functional lines finer than history and reason would support”).

In dividing official from unofficial conduct, courts may not inquire into the President’s motives. Such an inquiry would risk exposing even the most obvious instances of official conduct to judicial examination on the mere allegation of improper purpose, thereby intruding on the Article II interests that immunity seeks to protect. Indeed, “[i]t would seriously cripple the proper and effective administration of public affairs as entrusted to the executive branch of the government” if “[i]n exercising the functions of his office,” the President was “under an apprehension that the motives that control his official conduct may, at any time, become the subject of inquiry.” *Fitzgerald*, 457 U. S., at 745 (quoting *Spalding v. Vilas*, 161 U. S. 483, 498 (1896)). We thus rejected such inquiries in *Fitzgerald*. The plaintiff there contended that he was dismissed from the Air Force for retaliatory reasons. See 457 U. S., at 733–741, 756. The Air Force responded that the reorganization that led to Fitzgerald’s dismissal was undertaken to promote efficiency. *Ibid.* Because under Fitzgerald’s theory “an inquiry into the President’s motives could not be avoided,” we rejected the theory,